

Materialism and atheism



Although greatly influenced by Hegel, Ludwig Feuerbach developed a philosophy that was almost his polar opposite. Where Hegel was an idealist, believing reality was ultimately immaterial, Feuerbach was a materialist, denying the existence of any immaterial realm. And where Hegel had said that we project our ideals onto God, the 'Absolute Spirit', Feuerbach went further and suggested that we have in fact created an imaginary being embodying these ideals and then called it 'God'. Theology, he said, is simply anthropology, and rather than looking to the divine for guidance, we should examine ourselves as the true source of the virtues we ascribe to it. Feuerbach's moral philosophy was firmly based on this idea of human rather than godly virtues. His ideas were later adopted by some right-wing political philosophers, but Feuerbach was a left-liberal and his influence was most clearly felt in the philosophy of political revolution. His atheistic materialism became the link between Hegel's notions of the dialectical process of historical change and the *Zeitgeist*, and the ideas of Karl Marx.